

BANGALORE | Action Stations



B.K. RAMESH

GOWDA FLAGGING OFF THE FARMERS' TRAIN TO DELHI

Delhi for a protest against the acquisition of their lands in the Mysore-Mandya-Bangalore region. Gowda though flew to Delhi as his health did not allow him undertake such a long journey by train. Along with his army, another group of 1,000-odd BJP workers also chugged into one of Delhi's half-dozen main train

When it comes to mobilising mobs for support, the JD(S) has an edge over most other parties in Karnataka. On March 7, JD(S) chief and former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda and his son Kumaraswamy sent 1,500 farmers by a special 20-coach train from Bangalore to

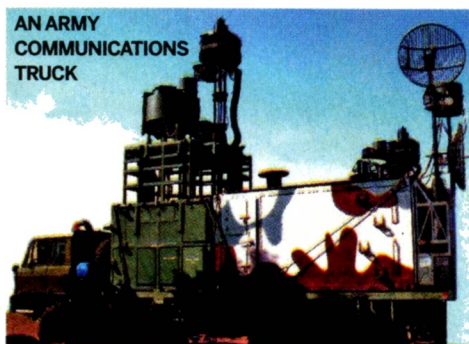
stations to protest the implementation of the Ranganath Mishra Committee report, which recommends reservation in government jobs and educational institutions for minorities and backward castes. The train tracks to Delhi have had a busy season. *by Stephen David*



With some disgruntled ministers dropping hints and a major revamp on the cards, there is talk of a cabinet reshuffle on Raisina Hill. But isn't this Government known for its slips between decision and execution?

DELHI | Private Ordeal

Less than two weeks after delivering platitudes on the role of the private sector in defence, the Ministry of Defence (MOD) is close to knocking five private sector firms out of a Rs 4,000-crore project to give the army new Tactical Communications System. The pilot project is to equip one strike corps of the army with a Tactical Communications System to enable high-speed secure communication on the move. The MOD's impending decision to give the contract to the state-owned Bharat Electronics Ltd will effectively knock private sector firms like Wipro, Mahindra, Tata and Rolta out of the race. The heads of these firms have made several trips to South Block to persuade the MOD



against doing so. "If the private sector cannot compete in information technology and communication projects then it has no reason to be in the defence sector," says a rather miffed chief of one of these private firms. *by Sandeep Unnithan*

KERALA | Right Moves

For A.K. Antony, development seems to precede political rivalry. A known opponent of the Marxists, the Union defence minister announced his camaraderie with the Leftists, attending the launch of a TV channel's studio backed by the CPI(M) at Thiruvananthapuram. ACHUTHANANDAN, ANTONY, KARAT AND MAMMOOTY



C. SHANKAR

puram. The studio was jointly inaugurated by Antony and CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat. Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan, Opposition leader Oommen Chandy and actor Mammooty, chairman of the channel, looked thrilled. Antony's defence: "Development should not be sabotaged by political rivalry." At the inauguration of a Coast Guard administrative block Antony said he had got an expansion project (of Vizhinjam port) cleared by the navy within 27 days, "after it was delayed for eight years".

by M.G. Radhakrishnan